



THE HUNTED: Mayawati with her posse of guards

states UTTAR PRADESH

PERCEPTION OF THREAT

A spike in the number of terror incidents has led to an increased demand from VIPs for heightened police protection, leaving inadequate security for the common people

■ **By Subhash Mishra**

Aspate of terror incidents in the recent past has led to increased security problems in Uttar Pradesh. Ironically, this has also become an excuse for people to enhance their social status by beefing up the number of gun-totting guards around them. In the last one month alone, Chief Minister Mayawati's security has been increased manifold. She has got the quick reaction team at her 5, Kalidas Marg official residence besides a special posse of the LMG-totting police personnel that mans the outer boundary of her residence. Her Shastri Bhavan office will soon be bullet proof and the distance between her office and residence is being cut short to decrease her movement on the road.

Not just the chief minister, the office

of the director-general of police has also been sanitised and entry restricted to the building. Even the police stations in Lucknow have been provided special bunkers and special security arrangements have been made at the office of the Special Task Force (STF), that has been pursuing terrorists in the state.

A senior police officer on the condition of anonymity said: "Mayawati's growing popularity that goes beyond Uttar Pradesh has become a serious threat to her life." This threat became apparent only after a chance encounter in which two Pakistan-based terrorists were killed in Lucknow on December 12 last year. A map indicating that the residence of the chief minister was their target was recovered from them. Additional Director General of Police (law and order and crime) Brij Lal says the state with three

Hindu shrines—Ayodhya, Mathura and Kashi—and the Taj Mahal has been on the hit list of terrorists for long. There were serial blasts at the collectorates in different places in Lucknow last month. A recent intelligence input says that terrorists might attempt to hijack a passenger plane too.

The moot question is whether the state needs so much security? Is the perception of threat genuine or is it an over reaction? Mayawati has been demanding SPG cover for herself and has written two letters to the Union Government. She has even asked for an amendment of the SPG Act and has put her relationship with the UPA Government at stake for this. She has charged the Centre for shielding an MP, Atiq Ahmed, who she claims poses a threat to her life. In May 1995, when the Kanshi Ram-led BSP had withdrawn